

What are the environmental effects of generative AI?

Posted by u/Kadakaus • 0 points • 2 comments

So I'm kind of new to this subreddit, though I've been salty about the social and cultural impact of AI ever since "brainrot" became a thing, but only recently did I find out that it has environmental impact as well, and I can't quite see through it.

Could somebody please explain how AI affects environment and what its results may be?

Comments

u/Mad_Jackalope • 1 points • 2026-02-10 12:47 UTC

There are several reasons, from the top of my head:

Power use: It uses a hell of a lot of computing power, way more than doing the same stuff with regular computing. In a time where most places finally tried to swap to renewable sources, the increased demand forces them to stay on the fossil power. Some server farms even just set up gas turbines that are terrible for air quality. There are interviews of CEOs complain that they bought their expensive chips and can not use them because there is not enough power to go around.

Water usage: Server farms need to be cooled, cooling water needs to be clean, so it uses drinking water, when many places have low supplies of it before. Also there are stories of drinking water becoming undrinkable after a close by serverfarm went online.

Waste: Chips for AI age fast, are often replaced, lose value fast and can not be reused for most other uses, so into the bin they go.

u/New-Transition-2997 • 1 points • 2026-03-10 10:01 UTC

how do any of these matter? there are countless more servers running tiktok, twitter, which take up as much if not more resources. but when its AI doing it, NOW its a problem?

u/Kadakaus • 1 points • 2026-02-10 17:37 UTC

Thank you for answering, it was a satisfactory explanation!